Hearts Aglow in the Ice and Snow

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Hurt/Comfort, Hypothermia, Angst with a Happy Ending, Fluff and Angst, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Established Relationship, Post-Canon, Protective Catra (She-Ra), Soft Catra (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Cuddling & Snuggling, Huddling For Warmth, Blankets, Winter, Snow and Ice, Holidays, One Shot

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Hearts Aglow in the Ice and Snow

by NotMyDestiny

Summary

A festive, wintery one-shot where Adora gets dangerously cold and Catra holds her through the thaw.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

The ice castle gleamed in the violet-blue dusk as Adora and Catra stepped out of the transport into the Kingdom of Snows. Icy spires towered above them, catching the last of the evening light. Their breath puffed white in the frigid air. Snow crunched underfoot. Shimmering snowflakes drifted down, landing on Adora's hair and Catra's ears like tiny frozen specks of lace.

Ice crystals hung in cascades from archways, casting the light into a thousand miniature rainbows that danced across the shining walls. Snow sculptures lined the path in abstract swirling forms, each one specially carved for the light festival and glowing softly from within. The courtyard sparkled like a dream, alive with colorful brightness, as if the snow itself were celebrating.

Catra and Adora walked slowly forward, enrobed in thick fur-trimmed coats, their shoulders brushing and hands joined. The air tasted of pine resin and the faint metallic bite of coming night. Adora's cheeks were already wind-kissed, and the tips of her ears pinkened beneath the rim of her hood. They heard the joyful sound of distant laughter muffled by the snow.

Adora stole glances at Catra, noting the low light reflecting in her beautiful heterochromatic eyes and the satisfied curl of her tail swaying confidently. When Adora squeezed her fingers, Catra squeezed back. She added a soft, rumbling purr that was just for Adora.

Adora whispered playfully in Catra's ear. "Last year, you almost threw a snowball at a dignitary."

Before Catra could reply, Frosta had appeared before them. The teenage ruler looked regal but excited in her elegant fur-trimmed robes. She gave Adora a quick, respectful nod and Catra a more casual smirk.

"You're later than I expected. I was starting to think you'd decided to spend the holiday somewhere warm and boring," Frosta declared.

“We wouldn’t miss it,” Adora replied with a warm smile.

“Good to see you both again.” Frosta glanced at Catra, “Try not to break anything this year.”

“No promises,” Catra replied with her own answering smirk.

Frosta waved them toward the castle. “Come on. Get inside before you both turn into popsicles.”

They ducked into the building to warm up, boots leaving melting trails on the polished floors. The hall around them was formed of glassy, gleaming ice. Overhead, chandeliers of suspended frozen crystals hung in clusters, each shard refracting the light into shifting beams that drifted across the floor. Despite its icy appearance, inside the palace, the chill eased.

Adora sighed, “Okay, now I can feel my toes again.”

Catra rubbed her hands together. “Speak for yourself. Pretty sure mine fell off in the courtyard.”

They stepped into a small side room, and the door clicked shut behind them. Adora fussed with her hood, fingers clumsy from the cold. Catra helped adjust her clasp and straightened her collar.

“These things are always the same. Too many people, too many rules, not enough exits,” Catra grumbled.

“It’s nice though, being a part of something that’s about light and community, instead of war.” Adora paused for a moment before continuing, “It’s our third year here. Frosta trusts me with this. The whole kingdom does. I want to get it right, for her, for them… for you. I just want things to be perfect.”

Catra brushed Adora’s cheek with her thumb. “It already is. You’re here.”

Adora’s throat tightened. “Catra…”

“And anyway,” Catra added, lips quirking, “if something does go wrong, you’ll deal with it. That’s also your whole thing. And then we’ll still end up in some corner with hot drinks and a blanket, because that’s our thing.”

Adora let out a shaky little laugh. “You make it sound so simple.”

“It is simple,” Catra said. “You don’t have to make it perfect. You just have to be you.”

Catra pulled Adora close. Snow was falling outside the window. Lacy ice patterns trailed along the edges of the glass. They kissed softly before they were interrupted by a sudden knock on the door for the start of the ceremony.

“Princess Adora, it's time,” a palace aide called out.

They arrived at the upper balcony. Townsfolk were gathered below, bundled in a sea of colorful fur-trimmed cloaks. Muffled crowd chatter carried on the wind. Snow flurries swirled in the glow of crystal lights. The ceremony started, and Adora channeled a small bit of She-Ra’s magic into a crystal and helped Frosta light up a series of ice pillars. They refracted magic into ribbons of light that interacted with the auroras overhead in a colorful dance.

As the lights burst across the sky, Catra watched Adora instead, noticing how the colors painted her features.

“You’re glowing,” Catra murmured.

“That’s just the reflection of the lights,” Adora insisted.

“Sure it is,” Catra replied softly.

After the ceremony, Catra suggested that they step away for some quiet time alone. “We could go smile at a hundred people we don’t know… or we could sneak away for five minutes.”

Adora exhaled. “You always know the right answer.”

“Obviously,” Catra agreed.

They headed out behind the castle, where the grounds were peaceful and calm. A fresh blanket of powdery snow made everything white and pristine, softening edges and muffling sound. The world felt hushed but for the occasional crisp gust of wind. Their dark coats were stark against all the white as they walked close beside one another.

Gleaming icicles and crystal branches glistened along the path, catching the light. Above them, the soft, colorful bands of aurora shimmered, joined by the distant glow of the magic-lit pillars to guide their way. Their footprints trailed behind them, leaving patterns in the untouched snow. The smell of damp wool and the subtle scent of evergreen hung in the chilled air.

Catra slid a hand into Adora’s, and her tail curled instinctively around Adora’s wrist. Their breaths puffed together.

Adora confided, “There were so many nights when I couldn't even imagine a future outside war. I never thought I’d get things like this. Lights and beauty and… you.”

Catra replied softly, “You don't have to be She-Ra tonight. Just be Adora. That’s all I want.”

They walked along the edge of a frozen lake. Its surface was opaque and sugared with drifting snow. It mirrored the aurora and the first pale stars above.

Adora’s eyes widened, “Look how perfect that snow is.”

“You’re not actually gonna… oh. Okay. We’re doing this.”

Adora, already sitting down, grinned up at her. “Come on, it’s tradition now. Third year’s a tradition, right?”

Catra, muttering but fond, “I’m pretty sure that’s not how that works.”

Adora let herself fall back softly, and powder sprayed up around her. She swept her arms and legs out until a lopsided angel lay imprinted beneath her.

Catra folded her arms. “I don’t take orders from precipitation.” But she found herself drawn to Adora’s smile.

After a theatrical sigh, she dropped beside her, copying the motion. As their wings overlapped, the aurora flared, lighting up two silhouettes frozen side-by-side on the white snow.

Fresh snowflakes drifted down, slow and fluffy. Adora leapt up, tongue out, spinning in circles like a delighted child. They’d wandered closer to the lake without realizing, the snow hiding where the shoreline ended, and the lake began. Adora caught a flake that melted instantly on the tip of her tongue.

Catra rolled her eyes, yet a smile tugged at the corner of her mouth. She sauntered closer, deliberately nonchalant, then flicked her tail so a puff of snow slapped Adora’s shoulder.

Adora’s answering laugh was bright as she bent down and scooped up a handful of snow, packing it into an uneven ball. She felt a small vibration through her boot. The first snowball burst against Catra’s chest. The second, returned with feline speed, exploded in Adora’s hair. A slight crack sounded from beneath her.

Adora hadn't even noticed her footing when the ground suddenly gave. The ice buckled. Fracture lines spread rapidly in a radiating pattern that might have been beautiful if it weren't so terrifying. With a sharp, awful sound, too loud for the quiet night, the ice dropped away like a trapdoor.

Her eyes reached for Catra’s, and for an instant she caught her wide, mismatched gaze before Adora plunged beneath dark water with a gasp at the shock of cold.

Sound vanished. There was only burning, overwhelming cold surrounding her. The weight of her coat pulled her down. Her limbs flailed in the water. She searched desperately for the broken

gap up above. Her thoughts came in fragments. Up to Catra. Hole for air.

“Adora!” The name ripped out of Catra.

Her eyes locked on the empty space where Adora no longer stood. One moment, Adora was laughing, and the next she was gone. The ice had shattered, the sound unbearable, leaving just a gaping hole where she should be.

Catra’s stomach dropped hard as the sudden fear of losing Adora again gripped her completely. Her body moved before her mind even caught up. She dropped to her knees. Claws scraped frantically against ice. Catra snarled, fierce with terror. What if she couldn’t save her?

Catra’s hand punched through the dark, churning surface. Her thoughts fractured like the ice. Was she too late? This couldn’t happen, not again, not this time. Then her hand fastened around Adora’s wrist. She hauled her upward. Water sheeted off of her. Adora emerged, coughing and sputtering.

“C-Catra?”

“Got you,” Catra said, voice rough with unshed tears. Both of them lay sprawled and panting on the snow.

Adora’s teeth chattered hard enough that Catra heard enamel click. Shivers rippled through her in uncontrollable waves. Her breath broke into shallow, ragged gasps. Her sodden coat had already started to stiffen in the icy air.

Without a thought, Catra pulled off her own thick coat and wrapped it around Adora’s shoulders, tugging it tight, as if she could seal warmth back into her by sheer force. She cupped Adora’s face with shaking hands and patted her too-pale cheek.

“Hey. Hey, you’re okay.” Catra said, voice low and urgent. “Stay with me, Adora. Look at me.”

Adora's gaze skated past Catra and then fought its way back. "Y-you… g-gave… y-your c-coat…" Her teeth chattered so hard it was hard to form words.

"Don't worry about me," Catra said. "I'm fine. You're the one who decided to go ice diving."

Her tail twitched, and her ears were flat. She slid an arm around Adora and hauled her up. Catra leaned in, brows furrowing, "We've gotta get you inside quick. Walk. Now."

Adora tried to stand, and her knees buckled at first. Catra clamped an arm around her waist, half-carrying her. "Hey, I've got you. Lean on me."

Adora stumbled, the world tilting dizzily. Her legs moved clumsily, a bit out of her control. Her thoughts came slow and slurred. Her lashes were starred with frozen droplets. Her shoulders hunched against the stinging bite of the wind. Numbness crept into her fingers and toes as the dull ache of the cold gnawed inward.

"M'fine. J-just…t-tired…" The words tumbled out in fragments between shaking teeth.

Adora's head lolled against Catra's shoulder, her lips blue, but she squeezed her hand lightly.

"See?" Catra breathed, clinging to that tiny pressure. "Knew you were stubborn."

Her tail lashed once, then wrapped tight around her own leg as if she could hold herself together by instinct alone. She bent her head closer to Adora's ear, voice dropping to a rough whisper. "Just a little farther, okay? Don't you dare check out on me now."

Startled guards and aides rushed to help, opening doors and ushering them inside. They stumbled through a side door into a sitting room where a fire crackled. A wave of warmth washed over Adora, but she still felt a bone-deep cold at her core.

Catra barked orders at the palace aides, and they brought over a pile of blankets, mugs of steaming hot cider and stoked the fire hotter before quickly leaving, fearful of Catra's snarls. Wet layers came off fast as Catra settled herself and Adora under two thick blankets on a large seat, moved close up to the fire.

Adora felt Catra's constant touch. She checked the pulse at her wrist. She gently smoothed wet hair off Adora's forehead, her fingers feather-light. Her knuckles grazed across her cheek, and Adora leaned into the touch.

Catra held Adora to her chest, tucking her cold hands between them both, and rubbing warmth back into her limbs in quick, desperate strokes. As she held Adora close, her thoughts swirled. Her mind filled with a fear she couldn't fight off with claws or anger, but a deeper kind that whispered she might not be enough.

Adora blinked up at her through the haze, groggy and distant, her gaze soft and unfocused. Her breathing was still shallow but steadier now. Her eyelashes fluttered, hazy blue locking weakly onto Catra's face.

"Stay awake for me, okay?" Catra broke off, forcing herself to take a breath to steady the tremor in her hands.

Adora's eyes slowly focused on Catra's face and on the worry etched so plainly there. Catra looked wild and fragile, like something that might bolt but had chosen to stay. Adora's hand twitched as if trying to find Catra's. Catra caught it, threading her fingers gently through Adora's slightly larger ones.

Catra reached for one of the steaming mugs. Her hand shook a bit as she held the cup to Adora's lips. Adora took a sip, and the heated liquid warmed her throat, pooling in her stomach, its warmth spreading outward through her limbs. Catra carefully wrapped Adora's fingers around the mug.

Warmth surged through Adora from its radiant heat. She cradled the mug by her face, the steam wafting comfortingly against her

cheek.

Adora's teeth clacked. "S–sorry… I didn't… see the ice…"

"Hey, no," Catra cut in, "None of that. It was an accident."

Catra rewrapped the blankets more securely around Adora, pulling them all the way to her chin as she seemed to shiver ever harder.

"You're going to steal all my heat, you know that?" Catra teased lightly as she pressed more firmly against her.

Adora tried to joke through chattering teeth, "C–consider it payback. You're al–always stealing the blankets."

Catra kept watch by counting breaths and feeling the slow, fragile warmth return to Adora's skin. Catra leaned closer still until their foreheads touched, trading heat. The shivers finally eased, and color returned to Adora's cheeks and lips as they turned a faint rose.

"No magic sword, or golden glow. Just you and me, still here after freezing our butts off in a snowbank," Catra teased.

Adora, realizing that was more than enough, let out a trembling breath. "Thank you."

"Always," Catra whispered, almost too low to hear.

Curled against each other in the mound of blankets, Catra's protective purr vibrated through them both. Two silhouettes melted together, feeling truly at home with one another.

"Next year we're skipping the ice walking tradition," Catra said softly.

"Yeah, that was never supposed to be one of our traditions," Adora agreed, her laughter soft, but real.

The sound settled something in Catra's chest. "Exactly. Let's keep it that way." Catra cupped Adora's face, now warm again, and kissed her lightly. "I love you."

"I love you too," Adora answered in a breath against her lips.

Outside, the faint prismatic light of the ceremony still glowed through the window. Inside, warmth pulsed between laced fingers and steady breaths. Two hearts were still stubbornly beating as one.



End Notes

I hope you enjoyed this wintery one-shot! Thanks for reading. Comments are always appreciated!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!